

Musical terms

Musical term	Meaning
accelerando, accel.	gradually increasing tempo
adagietto	slow, but faster than adagio
adagio	slow—a tempo between andante and largo
ad libitum, ad lib.	at choice—passage may be played loosely improvised, or part can be left out
affettuoso	tenderly
agitato	agitated
alla marcia	in the style of a march
allargando	broadening—getting slower and louder
allegretto	quick, but not as quick as allegro
allegro	quick
amabile	amiable, pleasant
andante	at a walking pace
andantino	slightly faster than andante
animando	more lively
animato, animé	animated, lively
a piacere	at pleasure—no need to follow rhythm strictly
appassionato	with passion
arco	bow of a string instrument, used if players have previously been asked to play pizzicato
a tempo	in time—return to the original speed
attacca	go straight on to the next section without a break
bravura	skill, brilliance (con bravura: in a brilliant style)
brio	vigor, animation
calmato	calm, tranquil
cantabile	in a singing style
capriccioso, capricieux	unpredictable, volatile
colla parte	keep with the soloist (for accompanist)
colla voce	keep with the singer (for accompanist)
col legno	with the wood (of a string instrument)—the player should play with the wood of the bow
come prima	as before (not necessarily as at the beginning)
come sopra	as above
comodo	convenient (tempo comodo: at a comfortable speed)
crescendo, cresc, cres.	gradually getting louder
da capo, D.C.	from the head—from the beginning

Musical term	Meaning
dal segno, D.S.	from the sign
deciso	decisively
decrescendo, decresc.	gradually getting softer
détaché	act of playing notes separately
diminuendo, dimin.	dwindling—with gradually decreasing volume
divisi, div.	divided—for orchestral players (usually strings) to divide into groups
dolce	sweetly (dolcissimo: as sweetly as possible)
douce, doux, doucement	softly, sweetly
energico	energetic
en retenant	slowing slightly, holding back
espressione	expression
espressivo, espress.	expressive
fin, fine	end
Flatterzunge, Flzg.	flutter-tonguing (for wind instruments)
forte, f	loud
fortepiano, fp	loud then immediately soft
fortissimo, ff, fff	very loud
forza	force (forzando, forzato, fz: forcing, accenting)
furioso	furious, frenzied
giocoso	playful, humorous
giusto	exact, proper (tempo giusto: in strict time)
glissando, gliss.	slide (for piano or harp)—sweeping finger along the keys or strings
G.P.	general pause—all performers silent
grandioso	grandly
grave	very slow, solemn
grazioso	graceful
joyeux	joyful
lacrimoso, lagrimando, lagrimoso	sad
lamentoso	lamenting
langsam	slow
largamente	broadly
larghetto	slow, but a little faster than largo
largo	slow
legato	smooth, with no break between notes